Tomb of the Gods

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/70891971.

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Mature

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Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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Gen

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta & Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Entrapta (She-Ra), Catra & Double Trouble (She-Ra), Adora & The Princess Alliance (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Other Additional Tags to Be Added, Alternate Universe - Bloodborne Fusion, Inspired by Bloodborne (Video Game), Don't Have to Know Bloodborne (Video Game), Insanity, Blood and Violence, Time Travel, Dehumanization, Double Trouble is an asshole (she-ra), Catra Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Angst, Canon-Typical Blood (Bloodborne), Canon-Typical Violence (Bloodborne), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Entrapta Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Everyone is having a super fun time for sure, Angst with No Happy Ending

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English

Series:
Part 11 of Of the Blood, By the Blood

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by Nny11

Summary

Beneath Etheria lies an intricate old labyrinth of myriad, endless ruins. By conducting a Chalice Ritual, the seal to the old labyrinth can be broken. Let the chalice reveal the tomb of the gods; let blood be the hunter's nourishment.

...And let ye partake in communion...

Chapter 1: Eternian Ihyll

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta knew, logically, that it's a bad sign when you begin to hear voices in your head. Not necessarily in general (although she would assume it was also bad in general), but specifically that it was a very bad sign after spending time in the labyrinth.

Chapter Notes

> I do HIGHLY recommend reading the rest of the series before this fic, this one definitely needs the context.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

She knew, logically, that it's a bad sign when you begin to hear voices in your head. Not necessarily in general (although she would assume it was also bad in general), but specifically that it was a very bad sign after spending time in the labyrinth.

Entrapta can still remember vividly the way that Hordak spoke of Minister Weaver before his accident. As a doomed woman, but admirable for her ability to shoulder her fate with conviction. She, personally, would've described the woman as kindly, distant, and haunted. Of course her opinion had changed since meeting Adora, and her feelings on the woman ended up much the same place they do for any other beast.

Melancholic, but detached. Cold but not cruel.

Still, the minister had done things no one else could even hope to replicate. She'd spent uninterrupted years down in the ever expanding labyrinth and come out sane. She'd been the first to document the watchers digging long enough to prove they were the ones creating the tunnels. Her blood had a higher potency and had allowed her to save many who just years prior were considered unsaveable. She'd helped to develop a method to

increase blood potential, which increased the number of ministers in the Horde. She had been the Provost of Mystacor before Entrapta's time, a Blood Minister, a member of the Choir of Eternal Light, leader of a Hunter faction- it was incredible! Genuinely remarkable what she'd done.

Entrapta wasn't sure whether she was proud or scared of the easy comparisons she saw between them. She could only hope that their differences would be enough to spare her the same fate. Especially as she was working in such unique conditions.

"Again? So soon?" Bow asked, swallowing repeatedly as if he was stopping other words from flowing out. He probably was. Bow was a man out of time in her opinion, he wasn't made for this life, this era, this epidemic. Nor was he well suited to this work. His technical skills were unmatched, it was something in him pushed and made him pull himself back. Leftover mechanism from the Horde. She would humor him.

"Well, yes," Entrapta nodded slowly, "we need more supplies, right?"

She knew they did, she'd helped him to assemble another three lamps for the city. Or the forest. Or wherever he wished to put them really. It didn't matter. Her own little pile of lamps was sitting and waiting for her back below ground, and she was decently sure that it was actually somewhere in the distant past. The labyrinth was strange in that way, part of the madness was driven by the time jumps; hunters going back too far and staying too long. It was as she made the lamps here for the alliance that Entrapta wondered if she had built them back then too. Someone else in her own past had studied her designs, noted them down, had their writings interpreted and misinterpreted, and the knowledge eventually passed back to her. From her to a middle man to a hazy memory to herself. It was possible. In the subterranean world where fires and incense burned without ceasing, moments were frozen in bubbles of time, and gods lurked behind hidden doorways… well, nothing was truly impossible down there. Four times now she's slain the same

nightmare, in the same room, on the same level only to then find it further down in the fifth depth even more horrific and powerful. It was incredible what happened below their feet. Truly she wished to return to her experiments and explorations, but she was willing to gather more supplies for the alliance as she did. It didn't hurt to help them now, even if it wouldn't matter then. If she played her hand right, perhaps it wouldn't matter at all.

Bow stared at the lamps on the table, bit his lower lip in thought. She already knew what he would say. "Perhaps someone else should go instead, give you a chance to rest up a bit? Or I could join you."

"I can work faster alone." It wasn't a condemnation of Bow's skills, being alone let her sneak about more or run past creatures when there was no reason to fight. It was harder to remain undetected with two hunters, especially when neither of them were truly dedicated to the cause and their lack of dedication came from different places as well. Nothing to unify them, to reason to risk it all for nothing. "And no one else knows what to look for."

Bow sighed heavily, "I have been reading your journals, you know. I think I could find at least some of these. Farm for the gems at least."

He could.

But he wouldn't.

Bow was too worried to abandon Glimmer to the dream, and time moved oddly between it and the waking world. He'd never responded well to her pointing that out, however, and she doubted he would do any better with the increased time dilation and discrepancies that delving as deeply as needed would require. It was more likely she would meet with Light Spinner and gain gems from her than from Bow, well intentioned or not.

Entrapta shrugged, tapped her fingers, wiggled her toes, "If you'd like to." She was trying to be polite through the whispers, but her

insatiable curiosity always won over her patience.

Something was calling to her and it sounded like singing as heard from deep underwater. Her heart beat painfully for a moment and Entrapta glanced at her hands to make sure she hadn't suddenly aged without noticing. It would be just her luck to have a coronary incident when she was so close to finding a solution. A perfect solution didn't exist, but there was a chance, however slim, that she could still find him. And if she could find him back then…

Hordak had been a hunter too, he'd delved deeper than most as he assisted his brother and Minister Weaver. He could be there in his present and her past and their future, unknowingly waiting.

The singing was a warning, a lullaby of fear and misery. She'd seen the singer once, only once. She recognized the distinctive braces across his body, his shirt stained with blood, and instead of a head something bulbous and covered in eyes and psychopomps which hid a spiral shaped mouth filled with razor sharp fangs and needles. Entrapta had barely survived the encounter, having fled quickly enough to drink her sedative before the black metal spikes could fully burst from her chest. She still had to pull the little spears out, some as thin as a human hair, afterwards when her hands had steadied enough to do so. It had taken far longer to convince herself to leave, to not look again, to not try to steal just one more glance at the facsimile of him.

Yes, the singing was a warning and not a subtle one at that.

But the singing stood between them, so it was easily ignored underground. A little more time is all she needs, and down there she has all the time that has ever existed.

"I'll see what I can do." Bow smiled that awful hollow smile of his.

"Perhaps I can be of assistance, if you mean it this time good hunter."

Entrapta squeezed her hands into fists as her chest tightened and head ached. The eternal monument to her shame, her failure. She'd never truly hated before Wrong Hordak sprang to life in this dream. She'd spent precious time as Bow and Glimmer went to Myscator to prepare the workshop, her automaton was heavily damaged but easily imbued with arcane magic from an empty shell. When he woke it should have been Hordak in him, she'd used the little unburnt flesh she could access from him, her own blood and wishes sent into the magic and ritual. She'd done everything right; it was despicable how wrong it came out. Still, she would not begrudge the others the use of him, whatever they chose to use him for. She simply wished to be left out of it.

Bow's smile became awkward and brittle, "Oh, Wrong Hordak, thank you! Uhm, let's go take a look at what I'd need then. See you down there, Entrapta."

Same song, different key on each repeat, a leitmotif she could never escape.

Bow would not join her. Wrong Hordak would be useless. She would go back below and work alone. And she'd get closer to finding him. There was no promise she would. Time. She had time.

Weeks or months would pass up here at the very most, but years would vanish for her. A funny little change to the regular flow of time in the dream. So far it would not change her body, not in ways she could notice at least. But she'd shoulder the lanterns and travel through parts of Eternia and even beyond. She had seen the swampy forest that used to be where Etheria now stood, the way the lad had looked before the city had ever come to be. Odd patches of it almost blooming from the rock, rotted and vile enough for the fumes alone to poison her. It was beautiful and unnatural. She almost envied the giants who stood watch in them. Almost.

"Entrapta, a moment, please."

She sighed but turned from the chalice to face the Captain, there was always something more to do here before she was permitted to take her leave. “Something I can help you with?”

Glimmer almost looked like a mirage, smeared at the edges from the magic in her before snapping fully into place in a way Entrapta’s mind could more fully comprehend. Today must have been a particularly bad day as Glimmer had decided to use the wheelchair Bow built from their old designs. The Captain hated the chair but when her leg hurt too much to walk, even with her cane, she had little choice. The pain was chronic and incurable, part of the never ending deal to keep the dream open and alive. Glimmer jerked her head towards the meadow and the great tree, her wheelchair creaked terribly as she turned and Entrapta cleared her throat of ancient smoke to follow without coughing. The singing swelled and quieted, but was never silent even in the presence of something like the Captain.

“You know, you are not bound here if you do not wish to help us anymore. None can say you didn’t do enough.” Glimmer spoke to the strange white flowers as she rolled across the uneven ground slowly, using her legs to help navigate without putting too much pressure.

Entrapta looked at them too, not quite coldblood flowers and not quite lumenflowers, petals too few and large for either, but they glowed more brightly as Glimmer passed them and faded by the time Entrapta reached them. “I like helping my friends.”

Glimmer stopped at the base of the tree, looking over her shoulder so Entrapta could see just the tip of her nose and a swirl of a distant nebula behind her ear. The singing became sharp even as it faded further. “Are we? Your friends, that is.”

No. Not really. Not anymore.

But time was immaterial, a circle unending. So as they’d once been her friends, they would be again, they would be forever as equally as they would be nothing to her.

“Yes. I’ve kept a chart if you’d like to see our levels.”

Glimmer smiled at that, small but genuine. Curious. Very curious. “No, but I thank you for the offer. Can I help you then?”

No. She never had. Oh, she’d tried, and Entrapta felt no ill will towards her for the effort. She was incapable the same as Bow, the same as the hunters who killed for them, the same as the kin in their flock.

Entrapta turned to walk closer to the tree, past Glimmer completely to stare up at the too big moon above them. Asking instead, “How have your experiments gone?”

There was a frustrated huff that was more than enough answer. “We grow stronger, but the gems don’t like my blood I fear. A shame, I’d hoped the last one would as it resonated well with angelic magic.”

Disappointing but not unexpected. Angella had not been the one to steal pure ancient blood to Brightmoon, angelic blood could be found in the gems from hundreds if not thousands of years ago. Of course it could be from someone like her, jumping through time, but Entrapta doubted it. Queen Angella wanted nothing more than to keep her people locked far away, more likely someone in the past going back further than one of her injured soldiers desperate enough to hide in the catacombs. She didn’t know who it could be, but she did not fear them either. They would meet or they wouldn’t, and the labyrinth itself would weed out those who didn’t belong.

They were one of Etheria’s best defenses, after all. Shelter for the city and death for interlopers.

“Hmm, well, I’ll keep an eye out for more like that one then, just in case.”

“If you come back, I would appreciate that.”

“I said I would.”

Glimmer chuckled grimly behind her. “No, you didn’t, and if you find whatever it is you seek I doubt you will think of us at all.”

Entrapta frowned to herself. She didn’t like that assessment. It wasn’t wrong, but she disliked it all the same. She heard the singing, faint and distant, no words as his voice fell into a slow vibrato. It wasn’t in her nature to deny the truth, no matter how unsatisfactory it was. “Fine. If I can, then.”

The wheelchair squeaked and something too powerful to be ignored stirred the wind around them. “Thank you. Do try to not leave a mess for me to clean up where I cannot follow.”

She couldn’t help the small grin that tugged at her lips. “It may be possible for you to be there and here, you never know.”

Past the moon further up into the sky, something stirred behind the too high clouds. Golden lightning danced in her eyes and left no shadows, no thunder, no signs. Curiouser.

“I highly doubt it, all is as she wills.”

The clouds churned unending, and for a moment Entrapta can see a long shining body of some kind. Too bright of a white to be real, glistening scales covered parts of it, their shapes slowly shifted too rapidly for her to understand. “And what does She-Ra will?”

There was another squeak, then a thud and heavy shuffling steps as Glimmer joined her at the wrought iron fence, both stared into the clouds and past the moon. “Can any mortal truly know the whims of the gods?”

Tiny mouths and flowers of eyes nipped at her shoulder as Glimmer shifted too close, each vanishing as swiftly as they’d come. Entrapta asked, “And you immortals? What do you know of their whims?”

Glimmer laughed darkly, “Only what is not wanted. Perhaps I’ll see you soon, Entrapta. Good hunting.”

The singing stopped as she turned away, her eardrums settled and the thunder in her head calmed as she walked without another word. There was no point to speaking now, they either had a new understanding or they did not. But Entrapta had a promise to keep.

“Oh, and Entrapta?” She paused to listen to the wind and the Captain’s breathing. “Be careful. Hunters are drawn to the depths because it sprouts from their very misdeeds. Things that should be kept secret. To try and uncover them… it would make for a pitiful tale of petty arrogance, really. And the things down there, well, they’ll hunt those too narrowly minded first.”

Entrapta flexed hands and clenched her jaw. She walked again slowly, mind turning the almost useless words around to examine and dismiss one by one.

Entrapta knows, logically, that she’s being ruthlessly pursued by something terrible.

She just can’t help that her fascination far exceeds her terror.

She only needs a little more time.

She must go deeper.

It’s the only way.

Chapter End Notes

> Definitely the most coldly detached Entrapta I've ever written and I am a little obsessed with her to be honest.

Chapter 2: Ailing Arcadia

Chapter Summary

Adora sees the world below, all is as Sh'ra wills it.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had once told her that promises and lies were both cheaply made, it had been the reason she'd used to guilt Adora into a blood pact as children. Adora had protested the idea, of course, because she protested everything that Catra did that made her uncomfortable. That made her feel less safe. Back then it was religion and blood that felt like a monster waiting to leap out at her. She hated herself for that plenty now, there was nowhere safe left, not even this cursed hunter's dream. But her pact to Catra, her refusals to Catra, is what left them both here in this never ending nightmare. Adora never made enough promises to break, but she'd certainly done the lying for them both. And now…

Well, promises made were vastly broken. The host of the dream, Captain Glimmer, was the only one who'd held to any of her promises. She taught Adora to control her magic, provided the occasional gem to massage into her blade, and provided information she held. But in return, Adora had become trapped in the dream with her. Constantly training or healing or recovering. Glimmer had plenty to teach, it just left Adora empty. Almost like she was floating through life now. No real pains, no hunger or thirst or need for sleep, but no joy either. Just her ever growing anger that danced between her white knuckled grip and shaking fingers. The few times she stepped out to hunt it felt boring, like she was scrubbing the floors of the clinic once again. So she remained in the dream to learn and loathe.

"You are doing good work." Glimmer assured her, face unreadable, almost detached as she spoke. "Sh'ra would protest if you did

otherwise, and my teachings would not stick. Take comfort in that."

Ha! Take comfort in the cold embrace of Sh'ra's will, sure, why not? What was the point of knowing how to throw arcane bolts, to cast light and fire and shadow, to heal from every source she could, when it made no difference? What was the point of it all? Worthless to hunt, worthless to live, worthless to learn, worthless to die- what was the damned point of it all when *she* was… gone.

In her mind's eye Catra was dressed for services, her top stained in odd splashes here and there a rusty brown, her hair barely contained by a tie. They always had a moment, brief as it was, after church to just breathe one another in. No matter what the others said, the time apart only made the ache sharper, the memories clung to her more violently than ever, like a drowning man whose desperation drowned his would be savior.

Glimmer almost gently cleared her throat, and Adora could smell a burning, bitter raspberry scent on the breeze as she refocused on here and now.

"...Still, perhaps it's best if I leave for a while." Adora spoke more to a spot over Glimmer's head than to her directly. It hurt to look at her too long and too closely, both for the pure magic in her and for the similarities she held.

Even so, she could see the sharp flash of her eyes before it faded. "If that's what you wish, you are free to leave, after all. Take advantage of it for those who can't."

She never could bring herself to do it though. It was an excuse at first to train, then rest, then heal, then learn and integrate with them. Ha. The rest of the alliance made her head ache. Entrapta's promise of studies vanished below ground, Frosta hunter with the wives, Mermista and Sea Hawk became more aggressive and sloppy in their hunts which ranged far and wide, Bow meant well and did little else, Perfuma… no, no, best not to think on it.

And now, of course, the beast they'd allowed shelter.

It was massive, at least two if not three heads taller that Adora and twice as wide. Muscles like steel rippled across its body, only interrupted by the deep red-brown carapice. It was the first creature she'd ever seen that didn't seem wolf like or just a shambling corpse. Worst of all, it could speak. It was sentient and responded logically, at times with warmth and kindness. But Adora knew better. She'd seen monsters like this before, she knew what would happen. It was inevitable, and its presence had shattered the delicate threads that held the alliance together as a united front.

She could feel its eyes turn to her, as if it could read her thoughts. Adora ignored it, continued to heal Frosta and grit her teeth through the topic at hand. "Entrapta always vanishes like this."

"Yes, but Perfuma said she's actually missing this time, and she heard it from Bow who knows best!" Frosta kicked her legs as Adora finished healing her, and Adora was able to remain standing without passing out. The only benefit of her training and work was giving her access to her power without needing days to recover anymore. "So I think we should go after her."

Of course she would, Frosta had become more reckless since Adora's powers came to light. Hell, she didn't even test her newly healed elbow this time. At the start she'd flex the limbs that were injured, or test her breathing, or check where she'd been bleeding with a look of awe and wonder. Now she expects it. She'd become bold as soon as she did. Instead of gratitude she simply hopped up and put her hands on her hips, already huffing, "I'm not lying!"

She's young, Adora reminds herself and almost instantly hears Catra's voice mutter, old enough to hunt, old enough to behave.

"I never said you were. I just think we should give it time until it's actually unusual." There's an odd clicking sound, and it takes her a moment to realize the beast is the source. "Something to add?"

She refuses to even look at it, focusing on cleaning her area instead.

"It does us all well to check on one another early. Even better to be direct. I've learned that the hard way."

It makes Adora want to spit fire. Her chest burns and heart races and she does everything in her power to calm down again, to not let such feelings arise. To crush them mercilessly.

When it arrived, bloody and dying between Mermista and Sea Hawk, they'd begged for her help on bent knees. Adora refused, but Glimmer had not, slashing her own wrist open to collect blood. She was not a blood minister, she was not even with the church, her blood powers coming from somewhere else. The taste and smell and even color all dead giveaways of something else. The beast healed and on hearing they hadn't saved the creature she'd been hunting with and she- IT had cried. Begged. Was denied. The beast had attacked her, and Mermista confirmed with all the guilt of the truly faithful that it had wanted blood.

As if their new pet beasty didn't. Ha!

"So have I," Adora barely managed to contain herself to a stone like tone, "first sign of… oddness- we do something. Decisively. This is not that."

Her blood sang as the creature approached, all the little messengers always appeared and reached so lovingly towards it. "If you are always going to dismiss me, the least you could do is look me in the eyes when you do."

A cold sweat broke out across her body even as her fury rose and was crushed again. "You can always leave if you don't like it."

"So could you."

Adora's whole body froze, her hands jerked, her jaw clenched. Is this how Catra had felt? Her whole existence boiled down to a

useful tool, everyone claiming to know what was best. Or perhaps just at the end when the rage became too much and she'd-

The creature sighed, but its voice left no room for argument and no softness to seek shelter in. "You're a coward."

The vial cracked in her hand as it walked away and Frosta followed, without a word to her.

She hated it here. She hated it! SHE HATED IT!

Who was this **beast** to tell her such things!? Where were her friends when she needed them!?

Dead. Her mind whispered it to her, brokenly. Her only friend was dead and Adora was a tool doing the most good she could. Why leave? Kill a few more beasts only for them to be replaced so fast it felt like they'd come back to life. Madame Razz had denied her entry to the Chapel, telling her to make her peace first. Her home was dead, the only house she'd known was destroyed and rotting. Here she'd brought back humans, true humans! She'd exorcised the snail, the fish, the snake, the boar, the bear- all burned out leaving the hunters alive. Out there, there was no one left to save.

"You know, she shouldn't need to be polite for you to treat her like a person."

Oh here we go!

Adora managed to pry her hand open, to let the glass fall to the ground where the little ones grabbed them and drug them away. A small burst of blue and white light and her hand healed too. She finally managed to speak and hated herself more for what came out without thought. "A held tongue can be a kindness."

"So, what!? It's okay for her to talk to me like that? To treat me like- like an animal just because I won't grovel at her feet!?"

"No, Catra, that's not what I'm saying! I just- you could just be a little more respectful is all I'm saying!"

Catra stared at her, first in shock, then with teary eyed anger. Adora wished she could rip her own tongue out. To take it back somehow. But she wasn't wrong, Weaver's only true complaint about the other girl was her attitude. She could at least try it to see if it would help by saying a please or thank you or just being silent for once.

Adora slept alone that night, and the next night she was grateful that Catra waited for Weaver to finish her trials and help her to bed. They never spoke of it again.

Her throat burned with smoke as she cleared it, Perfuma's silence bothered her more than she wanted to admit. "She isn't a person, Perfuma. Not anymore. She's a beast. I'm staying my hand, that counts for something."

"Congratulations, that must be difficult." Perfuma smiled small and sharp.

"Did you need something or are you just wanting to argue with me again?"

It was about the only way they seemed to interact, which grated at Adora. She could see the goodness in Perfuma; the kindness, the humanity. In many ways Perfuma was a better person than her! Yet Perfuma was the most mad of the lot, the least useful, the most unhinged, and fully unbearable. She spoke of the beasts like people, told stories of her interactions, retold their stories and jokes and pleas. Adora had demanded to know, but only once, why those she had loved had not been spared. She had not liked the way the woman had looked at her nor did she like her answer, "Curious you think them spared."

But here and now, Perfuma softened at last. "I need to go home, but I'd like someone to come with me. It is dangerous but it's… it's more than that."

Adora could understand that, but the fear she felt was overwhelming, and she meant to say no except then she heard

the beast laugh. The anger scared her, the way it popped out from the numbness and nothingness without warning. It felt like a warning and an omen. She had to leave before she did something unforgivable. Scorpia called her a coward, fine, here she could prove she wasn't, could prove she was willing to work with even the worst of the lot. Make the beast make the next move. Make sure that she did not start the killing, not again.

So, they left together.

Adora had still silently wiped away tears as she watched the sunrise for the first time in… gods, she didn't know how long. The warmth of the sun, the smell of the soil, the sight of a clear blue sky all doing something to her battered soul. It didn't matter they were there to investigate the death of something too powerful to die, she felt lighter just for seeing such splendor. It gave her focus.

They walked through the mostly quiet streets, Adora pausing to let Perfuma rush ahead and pull the beasts away from their path. Most chased her, tried to hunt her, only two seemed to understand she was helping them and went quietly, and only one had turned to attack Adora instead. She left its body to rot but would not be surprised if Perfuma would go back to bury it. Horrible, foul beasts. They should be burned, their tainted flesh and blood not left in the soil to sully Etheria further. She shook her head, best not to think about now. Yes, best not to think about at all. Survive. Just survive this day. She could take her hurts to heart later. Perhaps while watching the sunset.

"Here," Perfuma waved her behind a large door, cracked open just enough to slip inside and find herself in one of the rare outskirts of Etheria. A place between the towns, empty for unknown reasons. Either the land was sacred or cursed, there was no other reason for it in her opinion. And there, in the center of it all was a giant monster.

Her throat ached with purple smoke, eyes stung with acrid tears. It wasn't the same as Weaver. Not by a long shot, but it was

similar enough to ache. The corpse of something god-like.

“What made this one unique?” Adora asked as soon as she could get her tongue unstuck. She’d meant for transformation, but the message was not heard.

Perfuma was quiet for a long moment, hands cradling the giant, misshapen skull. “He was my father, and a great hunter.”

Weaver’s blood soaked breath drifted over the back of her neck, her slender fingers gripped Adora’s shoulders. It made her teeth ache. Best not to think about her. To not think about any of that.

Instead, she clarified. “Many great hunters turn into regular beasts. Why didn’t he?”

Perfuma huffed but didn’t answer as she gently smoothed its hair down before standing to carefully walk around its body. Nothing but bones and fur and thin strips of bloodless skin. The ground all around it was blackened or stained with old blood. Empty vials lay where some poor soul had desperately tried to survive, Adora doubted they did. Bone fragments littered the clearing, some too small to have come from this creature, most she’d guess would have. Perhaps the hunter who killed it used explosives? Weakened it but hurt themself in the process. The poor bastard was likely one of the crawling broken wolves in the area, their limbs too long and with too many joints.

She imagines that’s what Catra would’ve become if she’d had the chance. Perhaps one of the larger wolves with the misshapen legs that limped upright until they lunged. She hates the idea that Catra could’ve become something like this, but she would’ve been a great hunter. Perhaps it had been for the best. She was lost to her own thoughts until something finally shifted.

“It’s missing,” Perfuma muttered to herself, barely loud enough for the wind to carry her voice.

“Missing what?” Adora walked and crouched to look inside what once was the creature’s rib cage.

“His badge, the bones grew around it when he…” Perfuma sighed, “I’m sure you’d prefer not to hear about that business.”

She would. She wouldn’t. She didn’t know. How could they both have seen someone so important transform but had such opposing opinions? Did Perfuma not understand what it meant, or had her mind merely shattered in that moment? Perhaps she truly was mad, pupils un-shattered for now, but Adora would be vigilant.

“Regardless, he spent time in the tomb of the gods. I know Weaver did as well. Perhaps that ‘s the connection? I’ve heard tales of powerful tools that imbue the hunters that wield them with strange powers. My father said he once found a tool that allowed hunters to temporarily transform into a beast, although the hunter who used it was killed shortly after as a precautionary measure, the tool itself was destroyed. It could be proximity alone that allows such a dramatic difference.” It was a blatant bid for information. But-

Her mind stilled and skittered but her heart yearned, so Adora spoke. “Minister Weaver… she had a tool. An ancient eye of some kind. She said it would summon a piece of the cosmos, but I never saw her use it.” It wasn’t quite right, was it? There was something wrong, she tried to remember but it was too hazy from years of neglect.

“The other one who changed,” Perfuma asked, like nails across a chalkboard, “did they also turn like this? They would’ve been close to it by proxy.”

“That’s not your concern.”

Perfuma laughed, surprised and exhausted. “I’m afraid it is. If it is proximity then they too would have been like this. You could become this. I could too. Perhaps even Bow and Entrapta. The whole of the alliance is a threat to itself, it always has been, but we’ve all known those who traveled the old roads. So I ask again, did they turn like this?”

Adora stared at the beast with an aching heart. For a split second she stared too long at its skull, saw the human-like face on it, almost saw her face in it. “No. She looked like the ones that roam the streets, the Etherian hunters.”

“Then that is a good thing.”

She bit her tongue as Perfuma continued her inspections, instead pulling out the single lamp that Glimmer had given her, desperate to escape now that they’d arrived. Adora had never planted one before, but according to Glimmer and Bow that was the easy part, just stick it in the ground and use it as normal. She jammed it into the dirt with a grunt and kneeled, she felt too cold and slick with sweat, and sick to her stomach to remain. The little ones gurgled and moaned, bells tinkled as they grabbed her fingers.

Her mind raced as they grabbed her, too unfocused. Her heart beat oddly, unfocused, terror lanced through her but her thoughts were too disconnected to care.

What if Catra just hadn’t had enough time to fully transform? What if she would’ve been like that, like Weaver, but Adora killed her first? She’d healed Mermista as she transformed, still human enough to save. Catra had stayed upright, screaming in pain from the blade in her back, because Adora had been healing her too. She’d given up. She’d give up too quickly. She could have saved her, Adora could have **saved her** if she’d just trusted either of them enough to take the leap of faith. Catra had been transforming, she hadn’t been finished, she felt it with certainty.

NO!

No, that couldn’t be it! That couldn’t be it, that would kill her! Knowing it was truly her fault that Catra was dead- That would kill her and Adora was not ready to die! It couldn’t, it couldn’t be!

The catacombs. It was something in there that did this, not the tools! Weaver lived down there, Perfuma’s father must’ve too! Adora’s breath caught in her chest. Entrapta. Entrapta lived there

too now. Dangerous. Gods, they were all too dangerous, all close to falling. Entrapta would need to be healed, purged before she could become something horrific. And Entrapta was *missing*, gods be good, she was missing. What if she'd already turned? What if she was lost while hunting lamps, and now the longer she remained hidden the more imminent her transformation would be.

Adora tried to gasp, to pull her numb and cold hand back, her last thought a brief moment of clarity. *She needed to focus on where she wanted to go, and only where she wanted to go.* She wasn't doing that, Adora couldn't help herself. Catra wasn't like Weaver because she never went in the catacombs below, but Entrapta was and is and is missing. Bow had too. Gods alive, if Bow-

The bells tolled too fast, the wind whipped at her hair, the world faded into a terrified static.

When Adora opened her eyes next she was by an ancient, unlit lantern. The walls breathed around her, her heart beat in time with the drip drop plip plop of water, earth and mushroom and rot. The roughly hewn stones made her vision spin. She fumbled, hands shaking for the lamp desperate to return to the dream.

She stayed kneeling at the new tombstone she awoke at, a mass of messengers who had never appeared groaned from the grave. Adora trembled too hard to walk.

The will of Sh'ra. Perhaps it really was. Wherever she'd gone had been horrifying, that there was now an established link even more so. She did not know how she'd even made it there, according to what they knew it was impossible. But she'd gone and that meant any of them could go and become lost. Any of them, but they needed to find Entrapta, to save her!

A voice cut across her panic, saving her from herself. Not fast and sharp like a scalpel but like a pre-warmed blanket on a freezing night. "...do you need blood?"

Adora slowly turned her head, looking up and up and up at Scorpia's face. She felt no hate towards the woman, none. Instead she stared at Scorpia's pure black eyes that shone with nebulae and stars. The odd bits of hair that stuck out from her hard red shell. Even the slight bumps where her extendable fangs hid behind her lip. All of it was suddenly beautiful, a true gift from someone beyond the bells. And that made a stone of dread fall in her stomach. Was this the first sign of her own doom? She'd barely been underground for a minute, was it that rapid?

And it hit her. It didn't matter. She could heal herself. She could heal herself and Scorpia… Scorpia was already too far gone for such concerns. If she had trusted Catra perhaps this would all be horrible story they'd read about in the paper together. Her rage crystalized by her trip with Perfuma, her fear now honed towards a singular goal.

Adora's throat felt raw as she spoke. "N-no. No thank you. I… I do need to beg for your help. For Entrapta."

Scorpia stared at her, brow furrowed before slowly sinking to sit on the ground with her. "No need to beg. What do you need?"

Adora would grovel for forgiveness later, for now she explained everything she knew.

They needed to return to where the gods had taken her.

Chapter End Notes

A brief summary of the writing process for this chapter.

Me: Please accept a little of the trauma so we can move this plot forward!

Adora: Healing isn't circular and also, fuck you!

Chapter 3: Truth oft resembles madness, inaccessible to the dull of mine

Chapter Summary

> Double Trouble never turns down a gift, especially not ones beautifully tangled in its own guts and tears.
>
> Poor, poor Kitten.

No one could ever claim that Double Trouble was a saint, not in the old or new meanings of the word. No. They were nothing special, born mundane, raised painfully modestly, even took over the family business like a good child should. They'd been nothing to note. Until it was far too late.

Their fingers traced along the regolith of stones that had grown into shape around the roots that tangled up into everything inside Etheria's underworld. The pads skipped along easily, and any chips in their nails could be fixed instantly if they so wished. Sometimes it was nice to feel a little something now and then, no matter the good or bad of it. How long had it been since they descended into the wonders and horrors down here? Decades? Mere hours? It had to have at least been hours, and they were rather certain a century hadn't passed yet. Perhaps they needed to count further back though, not just down below the soil, but since they left their home entirely.

Plumeria, Old Etheria, the city beneath the city. They'd suffered their mother's holy workings and their father's drunken jealousy. The sickly sweet and burning smell of the moon would forever burn at the back of their throat. The smell of smoke when they burnt the whole thing down was a soothing blanket for their frustration. They could not help it, Double Trouble had truly been born for the stage and even religious dramatics couldn't top the way one spilled oil pot had taken their beast burning from banal to magnificent.

No. No saint at all, something much more entertaining.

Wasted down here, yet trapped. Their power- gods, the powers one could find in these dusty old tombs if they were brave or foolish enough to dive deeply- thrummed down here. They'd tried leaving and found themselves stuck, their flesh too tight and their bones too long. Unfortunate, very unfortunate really. But the transformations were something heaven sent, and they were not so boorish as to ignore such a wonderful gift.

Besides, someone needed to thin out the never ending stream of hunters who enjoyed diving down below as well. Some with their thighs' belted, others with weapons they couldn't even comprehend, all of them could be felled easily enough as the time called for it. And Double Trouble did enjoy the game of stalking them. One by one, through darkness and layers, they followed silently. Sometimes a hunter, sometimes a beast, sometimes a rat, sometimes a monster, just enough to always scare them. Make them back away around a corner to regroup only to jump forward to find nothing. The paranoia of knowing something had been there was enough to make most rattle. A few swipes from the darkness could get the rest. Ghosts did roam the dungeness halls, but Double Trouble made sure to be far more dangerous and far less tangible.

It was delightful! Each time they found a new way to have a laugh. Each time they enjoyed themselves until the hunter would slip and then they had no problem to slice clean through. And with the gift, they didn't even need their old weapons and armor. Beautiful as it was, they left it safe as could be in the little home they'd made tucked away behind a rare illusory wall. After all, they could make themselves wear anything, be anything they wanted. A few short seconds and poof!

All this was to say, Double Trouble was living a fine life.

They were just meant for something more than fine.

So they were quite pleased when the newest beast arrived. Or perhaps it was a hunter. It was clearly a beast, ragged and covered in blood old and new, it seemed almost mindless. Constantly moving, rarely fighting, always searching. Beasts down here were obsessive in their tasks, to dig a tunnel or guard a hallway or what have you. This one was unique for its obsessive forward march into oblivion without any clear goal. Double Trouble watched, near and far, as the creature darted past them, dodge, evaded, avoided. And that was very hunter like, it dressed like one, moved like one, it even spoke like one.

"I don't know. We will or we won't." It half growled one day after clawing its own chest until it bled. Its head tilted, but Double Trouble could hear nothing no matter which ears they tried on. Then it had laughed, bitterly laughed, "That's your mistake to bear."

Not trapped in a loop, not stuck in a moment, it changed and evolved. Growing thinner and weaker and sickly as it went. Double Trouble worried after it, like one might a stray cat pitifully mewling outside one's window.

They went ahead and killed a mad hunter and her mishappen dogs, left the bodies fresh and warm. The beast stumbled through within a half hour, drool fell thickly from a corner of its mouth before it shuffled forwards to collapse and eat from the dog. Interesting. Very interesting! No taste for human flesh apparently. When they retched and gagged, Double Trouble snorted. No taste for much apparently, no wonder the poor thing was skin and bones. It forced several bites down before sneering into the carcass, "Gods, I hope so."

Double Trouble worked hard to get it water and food, the wrapping for its bleeding feet ignored, the coat to help with the chill that sometimes made it shake looked at longingly before being discarded with rage. It was so difficult to keep alive! Like a little fair fish, destined to wheeze and die, flushed away like waste.

“They’re here, I know they are!” The creature snarled, crouched at one of the many unmanned campfires that burned away in the dark. It stared into the flames unblinking. “No. They never left. I would’ve known. They’re here. I’ll find them.”

And that was when Double Trouble’s mind began turning and swirling. They experimented with the clothes, different colors without the gore. It rang a bell, it tugged at something. The creature wandered and they followed as a guardian angel. Then came the creature’s face. It’s skin, it’s fur, estimations on certain parts of it. And it felt familiar, nervous but proud even in its hopelessness. The voice came last, practiced with pitching and clearing up the tone. And that was how, one night as they watched its fitful slumber that Double Trouble would gasp in her true voice, “Oh! How fun!”

Their Kitten! Oh how wonderful to find her once again, and based on what they knew, she was even looking for them. Oh it was sweet the way a pet, even one held for so short a time, would search for their masters long after they’ve gone! Precious!

So, they prepared themself for the show of a lifetime.

Kitten wandered and deteriorated, and only when even her desperate ramblings devolved to little more than mantra and prayer did they reveal themself.

Their blade missed by a hair’s width on purpose, and Kitten dodged magnificently. Despite her skeletal nature, she quick stepped as Double Trouble rolled past her, not only twisting to evade the next blow from their blade but the flaming arrows they’d triggered. Ah, so Kitten wasn’t ready to die without a fight then, that was good. That was very, very good. Whatever had happened to her, whatever she wanted from them, they could use it. She didn’t swing, smart enough to not use her claws on her betters, so they grabbed her fist in an iron grip to haul her forward, her neck almost sliced open on their blade. She went still, eyes wide, and something inside them flickered and moved. Very interesting!

“Well, well, well,” Double Trouble made their voice bright and loud from behind the false mask and it made her straighten her spine, “is that my favorite Kitten? My, my, what a sorry state you’re in.”

She went nearly limp in their grip, but the thing behind her eyes began to thrash.

“Still not a big talker, eh?” They chuckled deeply as they pushed their blade more firmly. “No matter, darling, it seems our paths are just fated to cross.”

The thing howled but her Kitten only nodded, pressing her throat hard enough to draw blood at last. “Kill me.”

They leaned closer, let their gaze go past the surface, let their gift sample her essence. Oh how disappointing. She meant it too. The growling bloody beast inside her, however, did not. If they were a scientist she would be the perfect subject to dissect.

“Now why would I do that?”

Fear, that was good, that was a very good sign. She could still fear. “You hunt hunters, I’ve turned, my fits of- kill me. I’ll beg, if that’s what you require.”

“Tempting, but you’ve now the claws for it without need for me. Let me rephrase my question. Why should I do that?” They snickered as they released her, letting the fear rise up oh so deliciously in the stagnant air.

“I can’t. I’ve tried; there’s something stopping me. I’m too dangerous up there.”

Double Trouble laughed, genuinely laughed, oh that was their sweet little Kitten! They reached out and tweaked her nose, patted her cheek as it puffed up with indignation. “Well, luckily you’re down here now instead!”

Something shattered as she fell to her knees. “Please.” They refused to move. “Please! I’ve tried, I really have- please!”

The thing inside her gnawed and clawed. If her guts could pour out they'd be shredded little red ribbons, beautiful for a perfect gift bow.

"Tell you what, let's make a deal, you and I. If you play your hand right, you can get everything you want and more. And if you don't, well, I expect you'll still get what you're asking for eventually." They stuck their hand out and waited.

She snarled, a growl ripped from her chest as her teeth bared in anger. The rage and the fire from her only fanned and fueled by an innocuous spilled jar without source. "W-what's the deal?"

They let the golden, honey like warmth spill up from their chest, and the mask that was their face right now responded in kind to smile.

Kitten jerked back, scrambling to her feet as they vanished into a cloud of purple and black smoke. They let the magic invigorate them, especially in the face of their Kitten's bravery for holding still after the shock. And then they let her stare.

Double Trouble stood now as she had once looked. The young scared human, but this version smiled with just enough cheek for show. They crossed their hands behind their back and walked around her frozen body. The sounds she made really were to die for! What a treat, what an absolute perfect treat! They'd eat the whole thing up just to make themself sick at this rate.

"You know," they sing-songed in her voice, "I don't think your heart's really in this one, Kitten. The sob story, the victim, no, no, no. What I'm offering is for your own good, darling, but I don't do freebies. You remember why I came down here, don't you?"

Her eyes filled with tears and blood and the sounds she made turned feral.

"Me-ow, you really aren't doing well, are you? What if I can help you with that, hm? Come on, humor me for old times sake!" Black smoke again, green and golden sparkles, and then they stood

again, now in beautiful red and black leather armor, fine chainmail barely noticeable after being blackened, a metal helm curved just enough for large beastial ears to move freely, stirrups that allowed hindclaws to scrape against the stone floor. “There’s power down here, my sweet. A perfect eternity at our fingertips! You like that, don’t you?”

Her teeth bared, claws extended. If she’d bothered to care for her own survival it perhaps would’ve been more intimidating. As it was, it was merely a bit of sprinkle on top.

“You know hunters always make their way to me these days, they want my power for themselves. It is mine, and mine alone, but oh they are just so greedy for it! But I am tired of fighting them, so here’s my deal: You fight for me instead, give me what I want, and when all is said and done I’ll have gotten into your skin. You want to die? Fine, if a hunter doesn’t get you, I can finish the job. In return you will protect me and tell me whatever I want to know.”

Honestly it was more in her favor than theirs, but this one always needed a purpose somewhere. A goal to chase hopelessly like a dog after its own tail.

“Want to know?” She echoed, eyes darting about to more critically survey the room she was in.

Far too late for that, Double Trouble had waited for her in this dead end for a reason. The bottleneck and swinging blades behind them would be enough to stop an attempt at running. And if only she would think it fully, she would try anyways, earn the death she thought she wanted.

Time for the sleight of hand, the dazzle of lights, the undivided attention of their audience. God, they did love a good show!

“Oh yes! I’d like to leave this dreary underground, and I think I could really make something of your sad little life.” They transformed once again, back to a human version of her, but older

than she'd ever been in that body. Small spots where wrinkles would clearly form, white and grey hairs barely mixed with brown, more muscular and even a tiny bit taller. They looked like the picture of a prefect hunter, the red and black leather now included boots and lacked the helm. A facsimile of their weapon hung from their belt, the blade's beauty as hypnotizing to their Kitten as ever. "Wouldn't that be nice? To know that everyone out there will know you made it? That you were smart enough, skilled enough to live? Perhaps they shouldn't have underestimated you. They should have trusted you just a bit more."

Oh there was that cute scowl, the rage banking with desire, the desperation cut before the release, and the disappointment that followed. The thing inside curled up protectively, but their Kitten firmed her jaw as the reality set in. She was allowed to want what they wanted, she was allowed to operate on her own terms as long as they fit their will. They offered nothing more than a collar with the vague promise of death at the end of it's long, long chain. And she knew it. And she hated it. And she'd take it regardless.

They held out their hand once more. "What do you say, Kitten? A life for a life, it's quite fair isn't it?"

She glared at it and only she saw it now. They'd weedle the truth out, find her secrets, play with her bones, and once they were bored they could move on to the next shiny toy. They smiled softly but confidently too, the last knife twisting and covered in too little frosting.

And she shook her own hand with trembling claws.

Gods, it was finally going to be interesting here!

Chapter 4: Those who go mad are merely thoughtful souls who failed to reach any conclusions

Chapter Summary

> A more perfect puppet, and this time she hadn't even needed to be broken first.
>
> Just worn down to the nub and handed a collar that felt like purpose.

It doesn't hurt at first. Not like it did with- Catra's mind recoiled from the name even as Melog pitifully mewled out to Scorpia. No. It doesn't hurt like that.

At first.

Catra's bloody, ruined clothes are replaced by Double Trouble's own kit. After all, they no longer had need for physical clothes, able to conjure whatever they wished at will. The feathered and scaled cape was heavy and the dust on it made her sneeze, but it fit her well enough thanks to the bottom few rows having rotted and fallen out. The shirt was tight enough that she left it unbuttoned for comfort, pants long enough that she had to roll the legs up and secure them with belts and ties. But the clothes were mostly clean and decently cared for, it felt indecent to wear them.

They smiled as if they could read her thoughts on the matter. “Down here things can be more and less than they seem. But you’ll never need to touch lye or starch again, and that is a boon, don’t you agree?” They waited until she nodded before they both moved on.

Still, it was ironic in many ways. Catra wore the bronze mask that hid her beastly visage and Double Trouble chose to look a beast now instead, their true face still concealed. They called it a

dragon, the mask, and claimed they chose their form based on it. To Catra they looked like an odd sort of lizard mixed with a beastly wolf of some kind. But the transformation worked as they intended for it to.

When the hunters came, and many did, they ignored the non-hostile beast and attacked her instead.

The first time she'd had no choice but to use claws and teeth, and it left her nearly catatonic as she battled for control with Melog afterwards. Double Trouble changed from congratulatory to annoyed in an instant, but had also given her the first thing she'd actually ever craved from them to prevent such a relapse.

The blade of mercy. A trick weapon from far off lands; it was filled with arcane power that burned her hands. It split easily into two and she had barely gotten the hang of that transformation when the second group of hunters arrived. It was sloppy and took far too long, but she eventually dispatched them and used their own vials of blood to heal herself at Double Trouble's command. They were no less brutal for her training that evening than they had been that morning and it left her too exhausted to care. The pain of the cuts and bruises and burns did not focus her, only made her crave an endless sleep.

Double Trouble never let her though. A few hours here and a few hours there, training and hunting and listening and obeying. "There is no honor in this, but it need be done. It's a mercy to hunters who are too far gone to stop themselves, you see. To come here, to seek this, even at the death of another hunter, it's too far, darling. Their minds are addled. It is a mercy we provide them."

The days had no sun to mark them, only the slow dimming and brightening of the bioluminescent moss that grew in patches along the upper tunnels. Catra learned to read it like a clock, even if she didn't know how accurate it was. She learned to read a lot of things she'd never needed to before.

Double Trouble did not teach so much as they corrected. They would watch from the shadows or perch on a ledge above her as she fought, silent as a held breath, and then descend afterwards to take her apart piece by piece. Her footwork was too loud. Her grip on the blade of mercy was too tight, she'd cramp before the fight was half done. She was wasting energy on kills that were already finished, striking again when she should already be moving. She listened. She had been trained by Weaver's economy of words and Melog's wordless urgency. And Double Trouble's corrections, however cruel in delivery, were at least precise in ways she was unused to.

She did not say thank you. She did not think it either. But her hands stopped cramping by the third cycle, and her footsteps grew quieter by the fifth.

The armor came piece by piece, as promised. Each debt added quietly to the running tally neither of them acknowledged aloud. A bracer from a Horde captain who'd lost herself in the depths of the second level, refitted to Catra's arm with Double Trouble's fingers bending the metal back as easily as cloth. A belt from a prospector whose mind had gone so completely she'd been hunting the same ghost for what the time bubbles suggested was thirty years. Boots from someone Catra never got a good look at, only the sound of their body dropping when Double Trouble grew bored of the game and frustrated with her inability to find them. Each piece settled onto her like a new stone in a wall she hadn't agreed to build.

She wore them all the same, because her feet had been bleeding for weeks. Funny how she always found some excuse.

Catra had barely gotten the barest history of Double Trouble's faction before the sixth group of hunters arrived. Faster to dispatch, but still a struggle.

Above ground she'd not seen almost any hunters, below it she was beginning to feel overwhelmed.

“Where the hell do they come from? Why aren’t they fighting the beasts up top?” Catra had hissed, angry and confused and aching from the seventh battle with multiple hunters. Melog growled inside her chest, but their own disgust and anger with her was enough to temper their attempts to speak.

Double Trouble had laughed at her for that one, motioning above them and then at the bodies surrounding them. “They are. Or perhaps they did. Some of them might still join the hunt.”

Catra kicked the nearest hunter’s lifeless body and grunted, “I doubt that.”

“Sweet thing, trust those who know better.”

It was her whole life. At times the weight of it crushed the breath from her, but when it manifested as the constricting walls pressing in, Double Trouble would take her to other places. Wide open spaces, giant caverns, even an abandoned partial city. It helped, even if it meant she had to kill the beasts inside them, even when she was not allowed to take anything. All the spoils went to them first, and they determined what she could need from it. Not that it had helped, what they chose to keep seemed nonsensical. The flower that grew from a creature’s head that would wilt and turn to dust within days. A handful of worthless shining coins. A rusted blade which held their attention until they forgot it and moved on. Half the time she was grateful for the breaks, for the time away, for the room above her head. The rest of it left her too much time to think. Too much time.

Far too much time all of the time.

Catra lost all sense of time as life went on. Without the sun, without a clock, without a true schedule there was no way to know how it passed. The moss glowed and darkened too many times to count.

Catra only grumbled about it once.

“Oh, that is so quaint!” Double Trouble had oozed condescension and petted her head like a house cat. “Don’t worry that pretty head of yours, time flows differently down here anyways. Bit of a lost cause to care.”

Their smile had grown grotesquely, stretching far beyond what the shape of their head suggested it could. The moment stretched tenuously, like a razor blade pressed to her neck. It looked like some of the beasts she’d seen up top before it vanished as quickly as it came, along with an eye roll. “Nothing? How boring you’ve become. Come along then.”

She did her best not to care. Not to question. Not to argue. Catra wondered what Minister Weaver would say if she could only see her now. A more perfect puppet, and this time she hadn’t even needed to be broken first. Just worn down to the nub and handed a collar that felt like purpose.

Miserable and mundane, but that was life she supposed.

Time marched on, perhaps warped as Double Trouble claimed, Catra wouldn’t know. Merely pushing forward through each new lesson and punishment in turn. The corrections were harsh to keep her sharp, shaping her self taught fighting into something more controlled and purposeful. But even that silver lining couldn’t last. Double Trouble’s knowledge only went so far and having been so long out of practice didn’t help. Then again, there were the more concerning moments too, slips on their part, cracks in the system. The most obvious the day that Catra had found a hunter’s body, long dead in an area they’d recently walked through. Its head smashed into pulp and fragments. She had approached it cautiously to investigate when Double Trouble dropped from above her.

“Sloppy work, Kitten, I am not pleased with this at all!” They huffed, but didn’t even give her a chance to speak up before continuing on, “It’s like you’ve learned nothing at all. Do you not like listening to me? Do you want to call our deal off?”

“No!” She’d scrambled for the words, the panic a dull thrill.

“Then watch your damned work and be lighter on your feet, I saw how wretchedly slow you were.” They grabbed her chin in a rough grip, tilting her head before nodding to themself, “We’ll fix that tonight. Yes we shall!”

She didn’t know what they meant by it, what game they were playing at, but it didn’t matter much. She wasn’t supposed to ask questions, just follow orders.

We hate this, Melog said quietly one evening, not angry, just reporting a fact.

“I know,” Catra said, not agreeing or disagreeing, simply existing.

Then let us leave! They begged and Catra did not respond. Not then at least.

There was only one time she’d tried to leave, to flee.

Tired and infuriated by the pains, the training, the unwanted touches and comments. Technically Double Trouble did not force her to do anything, but the threat of what they could do, or what they would withhold, was too great to deny them. She became swiftly lost, stumbling through swamps and deserts and sewers alike until she eventually reached a ladder. The tallest she’d ever seen. She climbed it desperately, climbed until her arms shook and her legs ached, nearly lost her grip as a body dropped onto her back when she finally reached a small landing. Catra had crept forward then until she heard voices. Voices that couldn’t be.

“What do you think we’ll do when it fills up?” Too young.

Then a familiar laugh… a too familiar laugh that made the hair on her body stand on end. “Fills up? Don’t be daft, it goes straight to the catacombs!”

“No it doesn’t!”

“It does! She told me so, the bodies go in and fall down, down, down until they SPLAT!”

“Ew! Catra, that’s gross!”

“Well, it’s true.”

“No it isn’t, you made that up to scare me. I know it!”

“Tch, you never did have any faith in me.”

The voices grew fainter, and she strained to hear the last words from Adora, perhaps the last time she’d ever hear her voice. “I mean, can you blame me?”

The pain she’d felt was indescribable. Catra pressed her back into the stone and held completely still until her heartbeat slowed enough that she could think past it. Adora truly had never trusted her, had she? And without trust, what exactly had she been mourning all this time? A cage that smelled like someone she loved. Made sweet only by the haze of memory and the simple naivety of truly believing the bars were there to protect her.

We deserve better, Melog’s voice was small and bitter. *We could have been something more than this.*

The smell of lightning and burning fur and ancient bones turned to dust filled her nose. A hole gaping in her memory like a bloody pit.

She was amazed to not hear Weaver’s voice drift from the hole for how loud the memory of her words rang in her head. “Covet not that which you are not. Strive to be colored by blood but clear of mind, lest you become a beast. And a beast is a curse, and a curse is a shackle.”

Catra blacked out, the first time in a long time. She awoke back in the little den Double Trouble had made, her body bruised and aching, Melog quietly curled up inside and, for the first time in

quite a long, long time they were morose instead of scared or angry.

It was a bad sign.

She thought about Scorpia's face when she'd left. Melog's silence when she'd taken the deal. The way even the worst of her impulses had tried to warn her and she'd filed every single one of them under cowardice and moved forward anyway. There was a thing Catra had always done, a particular and practiced way of taking every good piece of advice aimed at her and grinding it down until it looked like someone trying to control her. It was a useful skill. It had kept her sane under Weaver. It had kept her angry when anger was all she had to work with. Down here, with nothing left to be angry at except herself, she was beginning to understand the price. Melog was too tired to be angry with her for it, and that was somehow worse than the anger.

She groveled, quietly. They accepted it, quietly. Neither of them had much choice, it made the apology and forgiveness alike a bitter pill. Or perhaps it was poison? They'd learn soon enough. Soon enough.

The next day Double Trouble gave her the first target to hunt, not be stumbled upon, but to hunt. A hunter with a prospector badge, mad from the hunt and drunk off the blood. Catra spent several sleep cycles tracking him down. The hunt itself was hard fought once she did. He fought with a bestial fury, desperation leaking from his pores and fouling the air with his sweat, but he died, and his badge served as proof.

Double Trouble held it to the light, twisting it one way, then another before chuckling and pocketing it. "You know, I think it's time we take this somewhere more effective. Clearly you're ready, and I tire of this corner, don't you?"

As with all their interactions, they moved without waiting and Catra only hesitated a moment before following.

First down and down, then up and up, twists and turns turning her head inside out. Past incense burners and crackling braziers, through swarms of beasts and monsters alike. Double Trouble rambled about anything that came to mind, nothing and nonsense with a sharp blade waiting underneath.

"And the giants, I'm sure you've seen, quite the armory they seem to find, but who grafts it to them? The chains and the canons and hooks, surely they aren't born with such things! No, no, no, an experiment or a dance to dream, perhaps? Now don't look at me like that, or at least tell me you're own thoughts instead! Surely Spinner knows something?" Their eyes flashed gold and yellow and black and green, their head tilted, and then they continued on with another topic, as if the name had never come up at all.

Catra had never heard of someone called Spinner. She didn't think Double Trouble had either, that was the trouble with places like these. The warning that Minister Weaver had given her when dumping bodies, that the knowledge given down below was not always yours to keep. She'd said it with a sneer, as a warning, her typical cryptic nonsense. It made her head ache and shiver as it started to make more sense to her.

She did not want it to make sense. She did not like the memories that plagued her, Weavers and ***hers***. That's who Double Trouble reminded Catra of when they spoke like this, too fast and too knowing and too ignorant all at once.

It was so familiar it burned. Catra bit her tongue until she tasted blood, heart still aching from the freshness of her loss, still burning with contempt for her own softness.

She had made her choice, and we have made ours.

If only she could listen to anyone at all.

"You still with me?" Double Trouble poked her forehead, and when Catra refocused her eyes she yelped and leapt back.

Standing across from her was herself. Or the shape of herself, older than she'd ever been in that body, wearing armor she'd never own. She had seen this before, during the deal, but seeing it again in the open air of the tunnel did something different to her. It was a memory she'd been carrying like a stone in her chest and seeing it outside of her was almost worse than holding it. The figure looked back at her with that particular tilt of the head that was hers, had always been hers, and smiled with a confidence that had never been hers at all. Small spots where wrinkles would form. White and grey hairs barely mixed with brown. Muscles built from years of living instead of surviving.

Don't, Melog said, the single word small and very tired.

Catra looked away.

"Aw, don't look like that darling!" Double Trouble pouted, letting the illusion go as they circled her before snapping their fingers. "No one can have my powers, Kitten, not even you. I merely meant it seems a good time to fix your gear to fit you properly. After all, only one of us is good at slipping into the other's skin."

Leave, Melog begged, desperate as they had been when she first took the deal. *Run and never return.*

Whatever spine she'd once had had been thoroughly broken by that Plumerian beast, she'd spent too long pulling out the last shards of it from her skin since she'd come down to the depths. She didn't run. She caved again.

They mended and sewed and fashioned and refashioned. Catra brought back pieces of armor from those she killed, and Double Trouble worked near magic to change their size or shape or fit to her. Each one a new shackle, a new debt, a new promise of loyalty.

As she tracked her next prey she whispered to Melog, "I'm sorry. I'm sorry you're trapped with me. It's just the way it is. With me."

A flash of disgust and anger, then tiredness, but they laid down still to watch after her all the same.

It all became a blur, a malaise, a malady of her spirit. No home, no purpose, no life.

Until, one day, it all came snapping back into place.

Chapter 5: A hunter must hunt

Chapter Summary

> "What a sorry state you're in." The voice came from no direction in particular, from all of them at once, from the dark itself. "Intoxicated by the hunt, drenched in the blood of beasts and hunters alike. A sorry drunk too pathetic to die. I'll string you up like the filthy beast you are!" A sound like a thousand small bells, one after another, and then their eyes began to glow from every angle in the blackness. Yellow, and green, and white, arcing and spitting. "After all, a hunter must hunt."

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra had been dreaming of drowning.

Every night she woke on a muddy lake littered with broken wood planks and shattered masts, the moon looming above her too large and red to be real. No matter where she stumbled, the lake never ended. The painfully bright silver horizon merely went further and further as her feet sank deeper and deeper. Tiny hands grasped at her clothes, tugging her down. She dreamed of drowning, but not in mud or water. When her mouth finally dipped into the iridescent water it filled with blood. Her nose clogged with the bitter burning sweet scent of the moon. She could not drink the lake and she could not breathe under the thickening red waves. So every night she tried. And she failed. And she drowned. And she felt at peace as she slipped into death.

And then she woke into her living nightmare once more.

The moss said morning. Catra lay on her back in the den and stared at the ceiling and made herself breathe in and breathe out and breathe in again until the dream finished draining out of her. Melog stirred, slow and groggy, pressing warmth into the space

behind her ribs. Some mornings that was all they had left for one another. It was enough.

The latest hunter had come in the night, alone and blood-maddened, following some trail only they could smell. Catra had heard them from three rooms away. She'd been ready. The dispatch had been quick and clean, her footwork good now where it had once been loud, and the blade of mercy through the throat had been merciful in fact and not just in name. It still turned her stomach, the way they always looked surprised. As though they'd thought themselves immune to the same end they'd been handing out.

She cleaned her blades. She ate what she had. She tried not to think about the dream.

Soon, Melog said.

"I know," Catra said.

They had been saying it for some number of cycles now. Double Trouble had grown stranger, and stranger had become something else that Catra didn't have a clean word for. The paranoia had been there for a long time, the certainty that every hunter who descended was coming specifically for them, for the gift, for the power to wear any skin they pleased. But lately the spaces between interactions had grown longer, and when Double Trouble did appear they were looser, more scattered, the performance of themselves coming apart at the seams. They spoke to people who weren't there. They stopped correcting her footwork. Once, passing through one of the wide caverns, Catra had watched from a distance as they stood in the center of the space and turned in slow circles, talking to the dark with grand theatrical gestures, and received no answer, and smiled anyway.

She recognized it. She had watched it happen before, to someone she would not name.

We cannot stay, Melog said.

“I know,” Catra said. “But I can’t leave them like that either.”

Melog said nothing to that, which meant they understood even if they disagreed. But Catra had not slipped from under Double Trouble’s heel so much as the pressure had gone lopsided, forcing her out to the side. WIth them so lost, she could escape. Unlike her failed attempt where they had at least looked for her, Catra doubted they’d even notice her absence for far too long.

Was this how they had seen her when she first arrived then? A broken, miserable thing. Catra had tried to keep to her role, even with Melog’s pressing and prodding renewed. But in their slipping it simply couldn’t last. This couldn’t last. Not as it was, and for all that she had hated the collar, she missed its steadiness. Its pressure. Was it wrong of her to want to save a friend in need?

Melog snorted with disgust, at her, at them, at all of it. *They are no friend.*

No. Still.

Catra felt blood rising in her throat and swallowed the phantoms down again. “No. I suppose not.”

They growled at her but curled up tight, used to this push and pull now. She winced for them and flinched at the anger that laced through her chest. It was all falling apart.

The search took time, they were in none of the places she would normally find them, yet their voice still carried. Deep chuckles and high pitched cackling, conversational tones and theatrical declarations. Too far for her to make out the words, but the sound drew her deeper and deeper until it stopped right outside a place they had forbidden her from going.

Leave them then!

But she couldn’t. She just… she just couldn’t.

Instead she squared her shoulders and enter the gate to the deep hall. Double Trouble’s voice stopped instantly, even without looking, as if she had made another mistake with footing or form so loud it forced them to correct her again. This time though, their back was to her standing under an improbable stream of light. Their posture was wrong, pulled taut. Not in readiness, oh no, no no, but like a sharp bit of wire ready to snap. Catra tried to move silently then, but still they turned around before she was close. Their frown rooted her to the spot, it was so similar to Weaver’s that it stole her breath before they began to speak. Low and gravely, as if from disuse.

"You think I don't know what you're doing, what you're planning? Don't forget your place, Kitten. I know what you want."

Catra's hands went still. She hadn't been planning anything. She had been coming to check on them, which was its own kind of pathetic. "I don't-"

"I know what you want," they repeated, and their voice dropped into something wet and almost echoing as their limbs broke and reformed larger and more grotesque, their head growing large and bulbous. The bone lattice of their skull expanded outward as the skin split to accommodate it. Their eye sockets multiplied, empty and then not, filling with rolling yellow light as their fangs grew in. Catra felt her hands reach for her weapons before she'd consciously decided to. *Not again! Not again, please!* "I know what you want to steal from me! After all I've DONE FOR YOU! You would betray me to gain my powers." The laugh that came out of that throat had no business sounding so much like them. A smaller second pair of arms erupted in a bloody mess from their ribs, the wet tearing sound of it bouncing off every wall at once. "It can't save you Catra. You think you can take what's mine and transform back into a human!? Ha! Your outsides just reflect your insides now."

Didn't we? Melog paced inside her and Catra felt herself on the edge of the hazy in-between. She had craved it, yes, once, in her worst moments. The idea of wearing any face, any skin. But

craving was not the same as planning and she had never- she would not- Gods, please, not again. Not like this. It was a worthless plea, but in her desperation it slipped out regardless. Sh’ra, please!

They've gone the way that all hunters go, Melog said, and their voice was not gloating, only sad. *Have you not taken their mantle?*

She didn't have time to answer. Both sets of arms slammed into the ground, boxing her between them, and one giant clawed hand swept up to seal the door behind her with a crunch of stone she felt in her back teeth. Face to face now with the pulsating sack inside what their skull had become, she could see their many eyes rolling independently of one another, unfocused, frantic. Across their emaciated body sprung a layer of thin, course hair that seemed to catch the light and dim it unnaturally.

Then they giggled. The sound almost childlike, and almost entirely theirs.

"What's wrong? Unnerved by a beast? Ha! Let me tell you a little secret, darling, hunters are killers, nothing less. Rancid beasts, every last one of us. Some of us are just better at faking it, that's all."

Melog trilled in warning and Catra rolled left, barely clearing the massive arm that drove into the floor where she'd been standing. From pure muscle memory she dragged the blade of mercy across their knuckles as she went. Double Trouble roared with laughter.

"Are you mad, or is it your animal intuition?" Their hands slammed down, their feet stomped almost before she could get clear. Their tail swept her feet out from under her and she hit the ground hard on one palm, forcing her to roll back up and away. Never stop, never stop. She’d learned that fighting the hunters with the boom hammers. Get close when they’re big and don’t stop moving. "Oh, it doesn't even matter. You've got more blood on your hands than mine! Oh, you are a sick kitty!" Claws left deep grooves in the

stone as Catra moved, a quick step and swipe, then a roll and swipe to evade another kick. Every hit she landed did so with a sick twist in her stomach. "You've drunk the blood of half a town!"

She hadn't! She hadn't. She didn't think she had.

Don't think, Melog snapped. *Move!*

So she did. She dodged and side stepped and rolled, her hits barely seemed to hurt them. Each one met with a laugh instead of a scream. How to do it, how to make it out of this alive? Where was their weakness? *The soft bits*, Melog cooed at her, *the soft under bits and inner bits!*

Soft? Soft. The head.

She needed the head, it was the only thing soft enough to matter, but it sat above seven arms on a skeletal and elongated torso. If she had her old whip it would reach easily, but the blade of mercy was short. Much, much shorter. Catra feinted left and went right instead, close enough now to feel the heat radiating off their body, and drove both blades up into the underside of one arm at the joint. The arm buckled. Not enough, nowhere near enough, but Double Trouble's attention snapped down and their head dipped, swinging low. Just low enough. She jumped.

Her hands caught the edge of the skull and she hauled herself up fast, blades already moving. The eyes here were larger, closer together, and easier to find in the dark. Several went out under her hands before they recovered and wrenched their head sideways with a howl, flinging her across the hall. She hit a pillar hard and the air was forced from her lungs as she twisted to claw into the stone.

She didn't fall. She made herself not fall.

"Oh! That was most uncharitably done! Most uncharitably, indeed!" The barest flicker of light pulsed out from the ruined eyes as warning.

High ground was no longer her priority. Catra dropped and ran. She zig-zagged across the ancient hall, the stone floor exploding in chunks behind her as their beam tracked and missed and tracked again. She pressed her back into the thickest pillar she could find and held her breath as the beam of arcane light rushed past, unable to destroy something so thick.

The silence was worse than the noise had been, unnatural. It made her heart race, her palms became covered with sweat as she carefully looked to see what Double Trouble could possibly be doing.

But she could not see them anywhere.

"What a sorry state you're in." The voice came from no direction in particular, from all of them at once, from the dark itself. "Intoxicated by the hunt, drenched in the blood of beasts and hunters alike. A sorry drunk too pathetic to die. I'll string you up like the filthy beast you are!" A sound like a thousand small bells, one after another, and then their eyes began to glow from every angle in the blackness. Yellow, and green, and white, arcing and spitting. "After all, a hunter must hunt."

The pillar disintegrated as she ran, nowhere safe. The space had felt massive when she'd entered, now it felt far too small to contain the monster inside. The lights dimmed again, her night vision ruined enough to make her blink in the darkness. Once again there was stillness. The wrongness of it all.

Catra was already moving again. She had learned to read Double Trouble's pauses, the specific stillness before they committed to something large, and she felt it now a half second before they gathered themselves and leapt. The floor cracked where she'd been standing, the impact sending chunks of stone skittering across what was left of once grand stone floor. Too close! Far too close. The displaced air hit her back as she ran and Melog was screaming in her chest, *again, again, go again,* and she turned mid-run and went back toward them instead of away, sliding under the nearest arm as it swept for her, using the momentum to

drive both blades up into the lattice of their skull. More eyes went dark. Blood and magic poured from the wound and where it pooled the air went hot and acrid, eating into the floor and her boots as she scrambled to escape.

Good, good! Melog's pleasure was repulsive and she shared it completely, grinned fiercely as the desire to make them bleed screamed louder in her mind.

A misstep. Greedy for one more slash, she overcalculated and their tail connected, sending her spinning into the wall hard enough to white out her vision. It was Melog who found the vial and drove the needle in, and both of them who stood back up.

The acid was eating through everything now. The space was more limited, rubble and craters and pooled burning blood cutting off half her angles. She threw every knife she had, some found the eyes she'd aimed vaguely for. Then the fire bombs with their ticking delays. Every bullet from her gun spent upward into their eyes, or their brain, or both or neither. *The soft bits!* Melog almost cheered. Catra grimaced as it wasn't enough. Even with everything gone there was still more of them, still more eyes finding her, still that ancient arcane power gathering in the sac preparing for the next beam.

And then their head tilted. And they paused.

Her stomach dropped but they moved unhurried, while Catra desperately calculated her remaining options. Double Trouble raised one of their smaller arms and bit into it with their own fangs. Something dark ran down their wrist, absorbed back into their skin, and the wounds she'd given them knitted closed slightly. Not all the way. Just enough. They tilted their enormous head at her in the oddly familiar way, if they still had a mouth she knew they'd be smiling.

"Oh don't look so affronted, darling. Did you think this was free?"

Gods, no, she'd just thought she'd already paid the price for it. Melog snarled in her throat and in pure desperation led her to scoop a handful of pebbles from the broken ground and hurl them at their head.

Each bounced harmlessly off and Double Trouble shook with laughter.

And then they stopped.

The laughter first. Then the movement. A stillness that had nothing to do with calm, the stillness of something running out of the thing that had been keeping it going. The acid pooling under them was eating into their own feet now and they didn't seem to notice, or couldn't, or had stopped being able to distinguish between the floor and themselves. One of the smaller arms hung at a wrong angle, moving slightly even when the rest of them was still, like it was on a string being tugged.

Perhaps it was.

Black and green and golden smoke, and they shrank and shrank. Their blood vanished to mist. The acid thinned then slowly vanished. Catra quickly threw her half destroyed boots away, let her hind claws dig into the stone below her to prepare for a jump in any direction.

The crowfeather cape came first, dark and full and pristine, each feather catching the light of the ruined hall, sparkling lightly green and iridescent. The hat with its yellow plume, the black gloves, the black boots without a scuff on them. The mask where a beak should have been, not quite reptilian, not quite human, polished to a shine. The thick cloak seemed to float despite its weight, dancing slightly with their stillness the way it had on that rooftop what felt like a lifetime ago; back when she'd been weaponless and scared and they'd handed her a pistol and called her Kitten like it was a gift. Beautiful then. Beautiful now. Not a single thread of it worn or ragged or rotted out.

Catra looked down at herself without meaning to. At the cape with its missing bottom rows, the rolled and belted pants, the shirt she'd left unbuttoned for months.

That's not- Melog started.

"I know," Catra said. Seeing it all again still did something to her. Something she didn’t like.

"You think I'm playing a game?" They sneered, snarling as they leapt at her. The fake blade of mercy split into two gleaming knives aching to bury themselves in her chest.

"You could stop whenever you want." Catra had meant the attacks as she dodged backwards.

They laughed darkly, clearly taking a different meaning, as they twirled the blades in their hands. "I'm playing to win now, Kitten. So do me a favor and die for me."

It was almost like a dance. Demented as the thought was, they dodged and circled, spun and dipped. One moved in and the other moved back. The hall was destroyed around them, their space even more limited despite it feeling cavernous once again, and it only meant neither of them could stop entirely.

Catra felt something unlock in her chest and Melog purred with delight. Down here she had fought the way Double Trouble taught her, controlled and quiet and precise, and she had been good at it. But she hadn’t been using it. Not the whole fight. She was fast, not slow and deliberate. Low to the ground, using her hind claws on the stone for grip, letting Melog guide her weight through the turns. Her own style. The one she'd had before she came down here and tried to sand down into something more acceptable. A mundane sort of realization, one she felt foolish for not having made before. She could keep both, to some degree. She could still fight as herself, now more than ever. Catra could not beat them at their own game.

Double Trouble noticed. Of course they noticed.

"Oh, getting comfortable are we?" They spun the blade of mercy in one hand, easy and performative, but their footwork had shifted slightly. Catra couldn't have said how she knew; maybe it was Melog, maybe it was just the accumulated weight of watching them move for so long, but they were trying to adjust to her now. "How charming. I did wonder when you'd stop fighting like a student and start fighting like a beast."

"You say that like it's an insult," Catra said, Melog's smirk spreading across her face. She had no mind to care, it felt right.

They met her with the blade and the knife both, the split form quick and brutal, and she took a shallow cut across her forearm getting inside their reach. Worth it. She drove an elbow into their ribs and felt something shift that shouldn't, ducked the knife on the return swing and came up behind them, and for one moment they were tangled together with neither of them able to get clean leverage. Both breathing hard in each other's faces.

Double Trouble laughed. It almost sounded like the real thing.

Then a throwing knife appeared between their fingers and she had to let go as it sliced upwards, rolled backwards as they drew their arm back.

Catra changed her angle at the last moment, taking it in the shoulder instead of the neck. *Poisoned*, Melog growled. Well. Shit. The burn started immediately, slow and insistent, but she kept moving, more likely to die if she stopped. Prophetic choice as Double Trouble rolled the shotgun up from somewhere inside the greatcoat and fired, and the boom of it in the ruined hall was enormous, dust raining from what was left of the ceiling. She scrambled sideways, ears ringing, tucking behind a chunk of collapsed pillar as they fired again.

"Come now," Double Trouble called, and their voice was doing what it did when the performance was working, when they had an audience eating from their hand. "Don't be shy."

They're flagging, Melog said, quiet and certain.

Catra risked a look around the pillar. Double Trouble stood in the center of what was left of the hall, perfectly composed, shotgun ready. And Melog was right. The shotgun hand was shaking slightly, almost imperceptibly, in a way she recognized from hunters who'd pushed too far. The blade of mercy was lower than it should be. The wounds she'd given them hadn't fully closed, more than she'd given seemed to open if the gentle drip of blood was anything.

"You look tired," Catra sneered, twirling so the cape billowed out from cover and stole their shot. They growled and Catra stole another glance, they swayed gently on their feet before making themself stand solid again. The tools, the clothes, the weapons… they were made from Double Trouble themself. Each blade, each bullet took something out of them that they couldn't get back. They couldn't even heal themself without drinking their own blood, a cycle that couldn't last.

Yet they believed they would win. She could see it in every line of them. They weren't afraid because they hadn't considered the alternative seriously enough to be afraid. This was still a performance to them, still a stage, and despite what they'd said, it was still a game they were winning on points even as they bled.

Catra had never had the luxury of not taking it seriously.

She came over the pillar instead of around it, using the height to her advantage. Their shotgun came up and fired, and missed because she was already past it. She dropped onto them with all her weight behind the blade of mercy and they went down together. Double Trouble abandoned the shotgun to get both hands on her wrists pushing back up as if the blade wasn't buried deep into their chest, and for a moment it was purely physical. Claws and teeth and strength, and then something cracked in the air between them and Double Trouble threw her off with a force that wasn't quite human.

They stood. Their breathing was audible now.

"You," they said, and something had gone out of their voice entirely. Not the performance dropping, that still there, technically, the word came out shaped correctly. But there was nothing underneath it anymore to hold it up. They came at her again and this time there were no quips between the strikes, no pauses for effect, just the blade working in the patterns she already knew because she'd been drilled in them. Double Trouble was out of practice. It left Catra better at defending them than they were at landing each strike, and somewhere in the middle of it she realized they were trying to remember how to end the fight and couldn't quite find it.

Now, Melog said.

She took a cut and gave them three. On a regular person it would have incapacitated them fully. But Double Trouble snarled as their magic worked to fix the damage, just slow enough to be noticed. They stared at their arm, the mask hiding their thoughts before they looked up at her slowly.

"You think you've won something." Their voice came out thick and strange. They shook their head slightly, as if to clear it, and reached for the transformation. She could see them reaching for it, the same way she sometimes felt Melog pulling at her own edges. The smoke began to rise from their skin, black and green and gold, and for a moment she saw their previous form, the monstrous creature with eyes and arms, and then the stranger she didn’t know, and then the older Catra who had never existed and then-

It stuttered.

The smoke went thin. The shapes couldn't hold. What was left when it cleared was the form she knew best from underground, the lizard like creature that had handed her boots and corrected her footwork and patted her head and called her Kitten. Green-scaled and bleeding from more wounds than she'd given, one arm

hung useless and the other still wrong at the wrist. Too many joints, pale skin and claws on too long fingers.

Like this they were smaller than they'd been in either of the other forms. Just themselves, at the end of everything, with nowhere left to transform to.

They looked down at the wrong hand with an expression she couldn't read.

Then they fell to their knees.

“Oh.” Their hands lifted as they stared at the blood, and then they collapsed onto their side in a shaking heap and laughed, weakly, until the laughter turned into something quieter. They looked up at her with glassy unfocused eyes and smiled through bloody teeth. “Ah. I see. I’ve made a bit of a blunder, haven’t I?”

It was them. It was them again, in whatever way it had ever been them.

“Well then. Curtain call, as they say. Finish this.” They spoke plainly for perhaps the first time since she’d known them, “Come now. A hunter must hunt.”

Catra could feel the tears leaking from her eyes, exhaustion weighing every part of her down and even Melog lay silent. She stumbled to them, dropping heavily to her knees to gather their cold body against her own. “N-no, you- we can heal you up, get you somewhere that won’t feed the madness, I can-”

Double Trouble smiled, half genuine and half calculation. “Mad hunters are too dangerous to leave alive, and I am asking you to grant me mercy, Catra.”

Catra shook her head. She tried to think of another way and came up empty. She could only look at them again as they reached a finger out and pressed the pad of it gently to the flat of her blade, leaving a small blood stain.

"It's what they're named for."

They will transform again. Melog's voice was urgent, and logically she understood, but it felt so horrible to hear. Last time she'd been lost to the frenzy of blood with Weaver. This time she was the one watching it unfold in Double Trouble's shattered irises. *Like the patients.* Yes. She supposed so.

It was slow, hesitating and stuttering, and she had to make herself do each part of it separately. But the blade slid through their exposed neck easily. Squeaking against the bones as she applied too much force, then clattering as she put herself back together once more. She understood, now, why so few were performed to this particular hunt. It hurt in a way that hunting beasts never had and never would, even worse if the prey was pliant.

Catra sat with them until the cold coming off the stone became unbearable. Then she gathered herself, and her blade, and walked. Up and up and up and up until-

She blinked into the weak sunlight of Etheria for the first time in what felt like years.

It was ordinary light. Grey and thin and carrying the particular flat quality of a sky that couldn't decide on its weather. She stood in it and breathed and Melog curled tight and quiet inside her chest.

She had spent so long hating herself, thinking herself a beast, trying to play that role until it became true. But she wasn't, was she? She was a hunter and a monster, and the difference still mattered even if she was the only one left who thought so. The way she'd acted toward Scorpia, the way she'd taken the deal, the way she'd spent months following at the heel of someone whose madness she'd recognized and named and still not stopped submitting to. That had been the most beastly thing about her. Not the claws. Not Melog. She had done this to herself, she always had, she was the one at fault.

Catra was used to hating herself. It was shocking to discover how much deeper the loathing could go.

There was no making up for it, and no guarantee that she would change. But there was something now that she could do that no one else was suited for. She could hunt those that no one else could.

Catra walked slowly back along the streets, mostly empty in the day except the stray odd beast. Half transformed creatures that were no threat to her even in her exhaustion. Strange. How queer, the way she'd once feared them. She walked to the hidden entrance, ducking down and climbing to reach the twice abandoned workshop. Nothing had changed since she'd last stepped foot here, since she'd- gods, killed Scorpia. She bit her tongue hard enough to bleed as she stared, willing but not ready to start again.

Ironically, her first charge came to her. Catra had barely reached for the doorknob when a hunter attacked her.

They were small and quick, and Catra was tired. Running on fumes and not fully present as she ducked, dodged, and rushed them to stab up and in, ripping through their lungs. It wasn't a fight. Not really. And the hunter was so young. Too young. But they had waited in the shadows to ambush whoever came through that door, and she had come through the door. This one was not human anymore, no. No attempts to speak or stop, not human. There were so few humans left.

"There are no more humans left, only beasts." Melog had once giggled, years and years ago, twirling through her chest with ease as they tried to get her to spill more blood. *"We've a cure for that now, don't we?"*

She woke up hours later, blades cleaned and sharpened. The fire in the hearth burned once more and her cloak and mask had been

wiped down and hung on the wall. Melog always looked out for her when she couldn’t look out for herself, even after all this time and hurt. She put her cup of tea down and went outside to look at the remains of the young hunter.

Her throat was slit neatly. Two thin cuts.

Ah. Good. At least she’d given the girl mercy at the end.

Catra slowly took inventory. A spear that left frost in its wake and a few vials of blood were the only things of worth, and she stored them away quickly. Scorpia’s old shovel still sat patiently down the hill.

The girl was half her height, but to stop breasts from getting the remains the hole would still need to be deep.

She started digging.

Chapter End Notes

> If you're thinking to yourself, Nny, wasn't there only 4 chapters before?
>
> Shhhhh, double update for no reason in particular, it's all fine, things definitely aren't spiraling out of control. That's just not a me thing to do!
>
> *A door bursts open and I am buried under the hundreds of thousands of words that had spiraled out of my control over the years*

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